

KF37 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

In this lesson we will begin learning the **Three-Part Breath**.

Assume a stillness posture, lowering your chin a little as you lift the top of your head. While maintaining that upright posture, allow your shoulders to drop. Close your eyes and observe how your body moves as you breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

The three parts of the body that we use in this mindfulness exercise are the abdomen, the lower rib cage, and the upper chest. As you inhale, expand first the abdomen, then the lower rib cage, and lastly expand the upper chest. Feel your shoulders expand at the top of the breath and then exhale. Practice this sequence for one minute, inhaling with the abdomen, then with the lower rib cage, and, finally, with the upper chest. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Now, as you exhale, try to reverse that pattern. Collapse the upper chest under the collar bone first, then the lower rib cage, and lastly the abdomen. Pull your abdomen toward your spine as you exhale, but don't exhale completely. Stop just short of empty, before you feel the need to gasp for air. Inhale again and practice the three-part exhale. Repeat this pattern for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

And now, for one minute, practice combining the three-part inhale and the three-part exhale. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

You might explore a solid, confident pause just before the top of the inhale and another pause just before the bottom of the exhale. Stop short of a full inhale or exhale. Notice when you feel compelled to take a breath or have any feeling of strain or anxiety. This exercise helps you explore how you breathe. It also trains you to live within your limitations rather than depleting all your resources or indulging in excess. You learn to stop short of either extreme. Practice for another minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

When you inhale, try to smooth out the transitions from the abdomen to the lower rib cage, and from the lower rib cage to the upper chest. When you exhale, practice smoothing out the transitions in the reverse

order. You might imagine the breath flowing like a wave through your body. Continue to practice for one more minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Now return to relaxed and quiet breathing as you observe what is going on inside your skin. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Take a deep breath. Open your eyes and re-engage with the meeting. You might practice the **Three-Part Breath** for a few minutes during your personal meditation time.

Our hymn for this confession was written by George Matheson, a brilliant seminary student who went blind while at university. Blindness ruined his career, and his fiancé abandoned him. His sister cared for him until her marriage, and while everyone was enjoying themselves at her wedding, he wrote this famous hymn, *O Love that Will Not Let Me Go*.

O Love that will not let me go,
I rest my weary soul in Thee;
I give Thee back the life I owe,
That in Thine ocean depths
Its flow may richer, fuller be.¹

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

The angels of God rejoice when we practice KF Confession 9:²

We learn to withdraw from the Idol Self and begin investing in our True Self.

This lesson introduces the practice of **Flow Pages**. Writing without evaluating what you write can help you discover what is really going on in your True Self. The purpose of **Flow Pages** is not to fill up a notebook but to record the stream of your consciousness, perhaps after sleeping when your True Self has enjoyed some freedom from the lash of the Idol.

Like authentic play, writing **Flow Pages** allows your True Self to express its reality. Courageous stream-of-consciousness writing gives you a chance to see what is going on inside your skin. Through writing, you can face what you have been suppressing out of fear and pride. You might discover what is interfering with your growth, or you might unveil some compulsive needs. You learn to just *believe it* and rejoice in the truth of what you learn about yourself. You may also get some clarity about what is causing your suffering or threatening your pride, and that clarity might lead you to do a worksheet, a tap, or a **T-A-T** intervention.³

While you are writing, you will have lots of opportunity to practice non-judgment. You can even be playful with **Flow Pages**. As you write, just watch and see what happens! You can learn to simply believe and not judge what you are thinking, feeling, and writing. Most of us are constantly censoring our thoughts and feelings and judging them to be bad or stupid. We avoid *wrong* thoughts and *wrong* feelings because we

are afraid of self-hate, and we foster *right* thoughts and *right* feelings because they support our Idol's pride and legal systems. Perhaps you believe that writing is only valuable if it is clever, meets your standards of writing well, or expresses deep and original thoughts. You might judge that you should be able to write easily and passionately. You might unconsciously write to impress yourself or to please a teacher, a parent, or a pastor—or even to shock yourself or others. All of this judgment, pride, anxiety, and the desire to impress, control, and perform interferes with the authentic expression of who you are today.

Remember that your True Self is most likely underdeveloped and untrained. In the past, you have been unwilling to invest in your True Self because you have loathed its inability to live up to your imagined glory. It's important to remember that unseen forces that war against the soul have encouraged you to suppress your True Self because they know how powerful that self is—it's through the True Self that you become a weapon of orientation in this world.⁴

As you write, allow your True Self to speak out of its immaturity and underdevelopment, and be honest about what you feel and think today. No one will read your **Flow Pages** except you and God. Get used to looking at what is real about yourself through your writing. Take credit for what is positive and compassionately accept what is not. Over the weeks, you may see your True Self develop and respond to training, just like a beloved child who, having started out as a little savage, can now cheerfully pour the tea—or even change the world. I cannot predict how you will cheerfully pour your unique blend of tea, but I look forward to finding out! Your particular blend is the contribution of your design, and as you offer that design to your community and to the world, you will glorify your Creator and, also, yourself as His creature.

This week, buy a spiral notebook like the ones you used in school. You might write on the front page in large friendly letters: THIS IS NOT SCHOOL! You might also write a few sentences to remind yourself that the purpose of the notebook is to explore your True Self; it is for your eyes only. Clip a comfortable pen or pencil to your notebook and keep it in a private but easily accessible place. Schedule a regular time for writing. You might set a goal of filling up one to three pages, or you might set a timer and write for fifteen to thirty minutes. It's up to you. Try to keep your pen moving and, without judging, record whatever comes to the surface in your stream of consciousness. Think of it as play. Happy explorations! When you next meet with the group, you might share some of your discoveries.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, will You play with me? (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

The text for this lesson is **Matthew 18:1–11**, which we will read in my translation.

¹At that time the disciples came to Jesus and said, "Who then is greatest in the kingdom of the heavens?" ²And Jesus invited a little child to Himself and set the child before them

³and said, “What I say to you is real. Unless you turn around and become like children, you will not enter the kingdom of the heavens. ⁴Anyone then who gives up their pride like this child is the greatest in the kingdom of the heavens. ⁵And whoever, in My name, receives one like this child receives Me; ⁶but for the person who trips and entraps one of these little ones who trusts Me, it would be better to have a heavy millstone hung around his or her neck and be drowned in the depth of the sea. ⁷Woe to the world because it trips and entraps! What I mean is this: tripping and entrapments are inevitable, but there is further woe to that person through whom the tripping and entrapments come! ⁸Consider this: If your hand or your foot trips and entraps you, cut it off and throw it from you. It is better for you to enter life crippled or lame than to have two hands or two feet and be cast into the eternal fire. ⁹If your eye trips and entraps you, pluck it out and throw it from you. It is better for you to enter life with one eye than to have two eyes and be cast into the fiery hell. ¹⁰See that you do not disdain and undervalue one of these little ones, for I say to you that their angels in the heavens continually see the face of My Father, who is in the heavens. ¹¹For the Son of Man has come to rescue that which was lost.”

Take a deep breath.

To give you a little context, I'd like to point out that this passage is followed by the parable of the shepherd who leaves his large flock to seek and rescue the one sheep that is missing.

When I was very neurotic and compulsive, I took this passage to mean that in order to experience the life that God intended for me, I would have to practice great self-discipline and self-denial. I was taught that I had to get rid of the things that might entrap me. I was also taught to discount and even deny my real abilities and to abhor rather than explore my real assets. Developing real assets was considered dangerous to the soul, and self-loathing was seen as humble. I did not realize that what I thought was humility and sacrifice was actually neurotic pride. I feel almost sick when I think about how I continued for decades in that illusion, but I can also feel happy that God's mercy was greater than my misoriented beliefs. He saw my earnest desire to do the right thing, even though my efforts were misguided. God was trying to help and support me, but in my misoriented condition I was resisting His efforts.

Caring for our little ones is, of course, vitally important. In this passage, however, Jesus is also talking about us. The “little one” is your True Self. Jesus is teaching us that in order to become great in His kingdom, we must give up our pride and judgments and turn back to our original design. Turning back to our original design means giving up the Idol Self that we have created with its legal systems, pride, and fear-driven choices. Turning away from our pride system is going to feel really uncomfortable; if we choose to resist our Idol's demands, it will try to drive us back into slavery by punishing us with feelings of guilt, anxiety, and shame. When we slip out from under the Idol's control, we will often find ourselves acting in ways that are immature and messy because we need training—and that can feel humiliating, too. God's intention is for children to develop the potential of their original design with the support of loving karis relationships, and as adults, we develop the potential of our original design with the help of the karis community.

When we receive our created True Self as something precious and worthy of respect, we are actively receiving Jesus and, with Him, our Creator; and as we learn to receive our created self, we also learn to receive the created selves of those in our community. By honoring them, we honor our Creator.

It is a painful reality that in this life you will trip, make mistakes, and encounter traps. It is even more painful to realize that you often trip and entrap yourself. These traps sabotage your true development. The natural talents and abilities that you are proud of can also trip and entrap you, and it can be painful when you realize that you are using those skills to support your search for glory. Rather than condemning yourself for the misuse of your strengths, you can use your KF tools to unseat the Idol and learn how to employ those natural talents and trained abilities to fulfill your real potential and mission. In our Bible passage, our hands symbolize the things that we do, our feet symbolize the path we choose, and our eyes symbolize our perceptions or what we imagine. Through misorientation, we have actually enslaved our actions, our direction, and our imagination to the tyrannical Idol, which compulsively hungers to satisfy the insatiable *Glory of Me!*

With the help of your KF tools, you can let go of feeling entitled to familiar, convenient, and easy resolutions to your problems. You can let go of your slavery to the exalted and unrealistic goals that you impose on yourself and others. Instead, you can choose to become like a healthy, supported little child. You can explore your design and potential with eager wonder and with a childlike desire and determination to be like the Father who created you.

Children are not busy judging others or the world. Healthy children are minding their own business. What would your life be like if you were not regularly judging yourself, another person, or the world? Little children know that they need training, and they are willing to be trained by those who have proven themselves trustworthy. They are watching their parents to find out how to live. Are you watching someone? Are you asking to be trained? You might ask a person you trust, whose life is evidence of the kind of outcomes you want, to offer their guidance. You don't have to take their advice, but your willingness to ask is evidence of your humility.

If you did not experience a loving childhood, the heart of God is especially turned toward you. In this passage in the Gospel of Matthew, we see Jesus calling on the adults to support and protect the little children—and that includes children of adult age, who, like Peter Pan and the lost boys of Neverland, have never been nurtured and, therefore, have never grown up. As we grow up and become the people God created us to be, we become part of God's rescue team with the power to seek and rescue that which was lost. God gives this same mission to everyone who is connected to Him.

People get lost for many reasons, but we are all found by reconnecting to our Creator and returning to our original design. As adults, we can begin to re-parent ourselves and give ourselves the protection, love, and support that we did not receive as children. We can also spend time with KF members who have learned to extend themselves to support others in their growth. We discover that what is working for them will work for us. In Karis Fellowships, we are rebuilding our health and well-being and learning to live glorious lives, rising up out of death and hopelessness to become all that our Creator and Father intended us to be.

Your little child got lost, but Jesus is seeking for you. Why not try seeking Him rather than running, hiding, and fighting the process of being found? What a marvelous reunion that would be!

Our prayer might go something like this:

Savior, come and find me, whatever it takes. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume your meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider letting go of pride and becoming like a little child. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider letting go of pride and becoming like a little child again*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself. You can learn to recognize and honor them without allowing them to master you. *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Gently hold your experience in your awareness. Observe whatever tension you may be feeling as you *consider letting go of your pride and becoming like a little child. (Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing as you *consider letting go of your pride and becoming like a little child*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Try putting your fingertips on your cheeks. Do the tips of your fingers feel hot or cold? Just observe. *(Pause)* Gently maintain your awareness of whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider the possibility of letting go of pride like a little child*. Is your experience right now pleasant, unpleasant, or vague? Just observe. *(Pause)* What do you believe about becoming like a little child? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Are you afraid of something? *(Pause)* Observe your experience as just information, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Consider becoming like a little child again, but with the power and experience of an adult. Can you welcome the little child of your True Self? *(Pause)* Can you welcome the little child of someone else? Imagine welcoming a child who makes mistakes, who is also alive with wonder and joy, who needs comfort and care, and who needs to be protected and trained. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore becoming like a healthy, liberated little child.

- Welcome the gentle Holy Spirit of truth, who in turn welcomes you with truth and tenderness.
- Welcome your present reality and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.⁵

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I choose to become like a little child, I let go of the craving to make things go my way.
- As I choose to become like a little child, I let go of the craving for attention and admiration.
- As I choose to become like a little child, I let go of the craving to make myself safe and comfortable.
- As I choose to become like a little child, I let go of the craving to understand and have it all figured out. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for drawing us together to heal. Teach us childlike wonder as You continue to guide us to our glory and our truth. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with You. Help us invest in our true design by shedding old patterns of idolatry, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ *O Love that Will not Let Me Go* by George Matheson (1842–1906), www.youtube.com/watch?v=sxcnEBn1nA0, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=cejtIUBokdo&list=RDcejtIUBokdo&start_radio=1.

² Luke 15:10.

³ en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tapas_Acupressure_Technique.

⁴ Rom. 6:13.

⁵ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.